For better or for Verse

The Library Bar, The Leela Palace, New Delhi

If the chattering bubbles of prosecco were condensed to lyrical prose, it would probably read like a sonnet penned in gold; effervescent and sharp, distilled to distract like a lingering memory. With cocktails enjoying more than a spirited moment in tastes and textures, it's only fair that text pave the next crucible. With Literary Mixology, Volume II, The Leela uses experiential storytelling to drive the narrative of its new cocktail programme, drawing inspiration from celebrated literary works and their authors. Each cocktail offers a contemplative interpretation of the world it inhabits. The haunting emotions of Toni Morrison's *Beloved*, translates to a smoky, bittersweet harmony of gin, sake and mezcal to echo love and longing. The distillate uses the saline accent of Parmesan crackers to build on the unity of opposites. Carl Sagan's *Cosmos* summons the noir intrigue of boundless imagination with dill-infused gin, tequila, Mastiha, tomato water and Elder flower essence, balanced by the acidity from Supasawa. Eat if you must, but save calories for superlative liquid pleasures.

Price: Upwards of ₹1,400 per cocktail

Chumki Bharadwaj



Royal Repast

At Majlis, Noida

For long, Osama Jalali has been a chronicler of India's vanishing culinary heritage. Then he slowly started doing pop-ups to introduce discerning diners to a rare repertoire of lost dishes. Now, he has taken the logical next step with At Majlis, a fine-dine restaurant that transports you back to the kitchens of Mughal royalty. The décor is regal—think lavish dastarkhwans, exquisite murals and glass-bead curtains that offer private seating.

One inspiration behind the food is Noor Jahan, Emperor Jahangir's consort and the original gourmand—memorialised with a seven-coloured raita here. The other is Jalali's mother, the keeper of heirloom recipes, who herself was taught by the legendary khansamas of Rampur. Menu highlights include Mewa Mawa Kebab, Murgh Rampuri Seekh, Purani Dilli Fish Fry, Gobhi Musallam, Majlisi Taar Gosht and the Kathal Biryani. But the sweetest surprise comes last—the truly rare Majlisi Gosht Halwa. This is a sweet mutton pudding cooked in saffron and milk—and utterly mesmerising.

Price ₹3,000 (Meal for two without alcohol)



HIGH TABLE

RYU Oka, Leh

The Grand Dragon Ladakh's new pan-Asian restaurant, RYU Oka, is a heartfelt passion project. For Anjum Qadir, scion of the Abdu family that owns the hotel and the creative force behind the restaurant, this was an opportunity to highlighting Leh's special place in the storied Silk Route by including cuisines from across Asia. The interiors are inspired by the Japanese philosophy of wabi-sabi—finding beauty in imperfection—with mesmerising murals by Qadir's father, shibori upholstery designed in-house, rugged walls, delicate lattice screens and warm paper lanterns.

The whimsical menu inspired by the seasons includes crowd pleasers like tofu spinach gomae, rock shrimp tempura and sesame prawn toast. There's a sizeable selection of dimsum and sushi, challenging to pull off at high altitudes, and a conscious effort to include local ingredients like apricot, seabuckthorn, mongol leaves and barley. In line with local tradition, cocktails have a minimal presence but whatever they have conjured up is heady stuff. Save some room for the Vietnamese coffee milk cake and seabuckthorn apple pie.

Price ₹5,000 (meal for two with drinks); Where The Grand Dragon Ladakh, Leh, Union Territory of Ladakh